After the Test series, I decided to withdraw from the one-day series. There was speculation that it was because I didn't want to get the hundred in an ODI against the West Indies, but that had nothing to do with it. My big toe had started to trouble me again. I was finding it difficult to change direction while running and simply could not cope with the pressure of one-day cricket. I knew I needed to do something about it before the next Test series in Australia.

India in Australia, December 2011–February 2012

I left for Australia on 8 December to get acclimatized to the conditions and be fully prepared for the Boxing Day Test in Melbourne. The injury hadn't disappeared completely and I went to a podiatrist to get the toe examined again. When I tried out some new insoles, the experiment actually made things worse and I had to go back to my old ones, but that was when I came up with the idea of using corn caps. These were cut in the shape of doughnuts and filled with jelly, and were placed right underneath the toe to absorb the pressure of the spikes. They seemed to work to a certain extent. The first time we had to apply the strapping, it took about forty-five minutes, because we were still figuring out exactly how to do it so that the padding stayed in the same place throughout the day. Within a week it was taking twenty minutes and soon I was doing the strapping myself in my own room, so that I didn't have to start every day in the physio's room. Every night during Test matches, I would get the tape ready and cut it to the exact size. That way I got a few extra minutes in the morning and wasn't so rushed.

In the Boxing Day Test at the MCG we started extremely well, bowling Australia out for 333 in their first innings, In our reply, I came in when the score was 97–2 and found that I was moving as well as I had done in years and I was able to play all my shots. For example, in the first over after tea I was in complete control against Peter Siddle, the leader of their attack. After hitting the first ball for six over third man, I flicked him for three runs the very next ball. In the thirty-fifth over of our innings, I hit him for two consecutive fours, the second of which was a cover drive I particularly remember. The ball was pitched slightly outside off stump and I sent it racing to the boundary.